The Battle for the Window with Luis Bush & Beverly Pegues used with permission of Grant McClung

An estimated 95 percent of the world's unreached people live in an area that is referred to as the 10/40 Window. This spiritually dark region of the world is located 10 degrees to 40 degrees north of the equator, spanning the globe from West Africa through the Middle East and Central Asia to East Asia. The 10/40 Window includes approximately 60 countries. Every major non-Christian religion—Islam, Buddhism, Hinduism, animism, and indigenous religions, as well as atheism—has its headquarters in the 10/40 Window. This area is also home to 85 percent of the world's poorest of the poor.

How many people reside in the Window? A staggering 3.6 billion! This represents two-thirds of the earth's population. Of these, as many as 1.4 billion have never had a chance to hear the Gospel. God is concerned about these billions of people. Therefore, it is crucial for the Church to seek God for His strategy to reach this spiritually impoverished region.

Some observers of current trends in the 10/40 Window feel that the task of penetrating and overpowering the demonic strongholds there seems almost impossible. In 1997 alone, according to the World Evangelization Research Center (WERC) database, 160,000 believers worldwide were brutally martyred. This means that, on average, every day 438 Christians died for their faith, most of them in the 10/40 Window.

While people in North America and other parts of the free world have innumerable opportunities to be exposed to the Gospel, the likelihood of hearing the Gospel even one time in some 10/40 Window countries is almost nil. It is estimated that more than 77,000 people die each day in the 10/40 Window without ever having had an opportunity to hear the Gospel message in their own language and in a culturally sensitive way. In India alone, over 23,000 people die daily, many never once having heard the Good News.

It is heart-wrenching to know that more than a billion people may live, die, and eternally perish in the 10/40 Window without understanding God's plan of salvation. In this region the demons of hell have launched a major attack to destroy people whom Jesus Christ died to set free. The 10/40 Window represents Satan's last geographic stronghold. And the battle for the souls of these unreached people is fierce.

Yet the power of our God completely eclipses that of the devil. Now is the hour for the army of the Lord to fight an intense spiritual battle and to seek the release of 3.6 billion souls from the ironclad grip of the powers of darkness. The Church of Jesus Christ must respond to God's call to help the 10/40 Window nations escape the devil's deadly deception.

We are the United Nations task force God will use to bring His salvation message to the perishing, persecuted, and impoverished. God has given us the incredible gift of prayer with which to seek His strategies to reach the 10/40 Window nations. And prayer is a mighty weapon of our spiritual warfare (2 Cor. 10:4).

Burden for Breakthrough

On one of my journeys into the 10/40 Window in June 1991, I (Luis) traveled to Japan, Thailand, and Bangladesh. That trip created an enormous burden in my soul. During my first night in Bangkok, I witnessed the needs of the city personally. Poverty, prostitution, child prostitution, unsanitary conditions, AIDS, and drugs were everywhere. In the face of such depravity, the words of Jesus in the ninth chapter of Mark took on fresh meaning for me. In that passage, Jesus had come down from the mountain following His transfiguration and encountered a boy possessed by an evil spirit that was robbing him of his speech. The disciples

asked why they could not drive out the demon. Jesus replied, "This kind can come out only by prayer" (v. 29).

Revelation of the need for massive prayer for the unreached was driven home to me as I stood in the airport in the city of Chittagong, Bangladesh, preparing to return to Dhaka. Many passengers had flight connections in Dhaka to go on to Mecca for the *hajj*, or Islamic pilgrimage. I watched in amazement as a Muslim stepped up onto a table while waiting for his plane and proceeded to go through his prayer ritual. "What would it take for the spiritual eyes of Muslims to be opened to see that Jesus is not only a prophet, but the Son of God?" I asked myself.

On arrival back in Dhaka, I could not sleep. Finally, I arose and wrote a letter to fax to Peter Wagner, coordinator of the AD2000 United Prayer Track. The date was 13 June 1991.

"It's 3:00 a.m. and I cannot sleep," the letter began. "I have a growing burden to see a spiritual breakthrough and an outpouring of God's Spirit that I must share with you. Peter, if we are to see a spiritual breakthrough and an advance of the Gospel so that the Church is established in the 10/40 Window world by AD2000, it is going to take an enormous prayer and fasting initiative. We need a mighty army of strategic-level prayer warriors saying, 'Lord, give me the 10/40 Window or I'll die.' We need at least one million who are prepared to pray until breakthrough occurs."

The same day I faxed the board chairman of the ministry with which I was involved, seeking early release to give priority to the call of the AD2000 and Beyond Movement and to the 10/40 Window.

The Window Comes into View

My (Luis) intellectual journey through the 10/40 Window began a few years earlier. It came on the occasion of a

Christian consultation called Lausanne II, held in Manila in 1989. Representatives from 170 countries attended. We developed a theme, the "Challenge Before Us." In one of the opening sessions, I learned that most of the world's unreached people groups live in this resistant belt from latitude 10 degrees north to 40 degrees north of the equator, although the region had not yet acquired its own name.

One year later, at the first meeting of the International Board of the AD2000 and Beyond Movement, we struggled with questions. "What would it take to see a church for every people and the Gospel for every person by the year 2000?" Then it hit us like a ton of bricks! "If we are serious about providing a valid opportunity for every people and city to experience the love, truth, and saving power of Jesus Christ, we cannot ignore the reality that we must concentrate on this region of the world."

The evening following the meeting, the many reasons for focusing on that part of the globe began to crystallize. The image of a rectangular-shaped box began to formulate. But what should we call this region? At first it was described as the 10/40 Box. But several months later, awakening one morning to the beauty of a new day and majestic redwood trees framed by our window, the first words that came to my wife, Doris, and me captured a new idea: "Rather than a 10/40 box, why not think of it as the 10/40 Window? A window is a picture of hope, light, life, and vision."

Then in June 1992, a group of leaders met at Every Home for Christ in Colorado Springs, Colorado, to discuss ways to organize a global prayer movement to penetrate the powers of darkness in the 10/40 Window. Intercessors prayed fervently in the next room as the leaders were guided by the Holy Spirit in setting up the foundation for this prayer movement. Ted Haggard, senior pastor of New Life Church in Colorado Springs, volunteered to staff an office in his

church to coordinate prayer journeyers and home-based intercessors to pray for the 10/40 Window nations. This became the Christian Information Network (CIN). Pastor Haggard also said he knew the person who should coordinate the prayer effort—Beverly Pegues, who happened to be one of the intercessors praying in the next room.

Things took off from there. The AD2000 United Prayer Track would network with other ministries to develop the *Praying Through The Window* endeavor as we know it today. This endeavor placed a significant emphasis on encouraging believers to form prayer teams to intercede on site in the Window nations. We sought believers from across the globe who were willing to take time off from work with or without pay and raise their own funds to go as God's ambassadors to pray in the Window nations. The participation was surprising and encouraging.

Praying Through The Window

The first *Praying Through The Window* effort aimed to mobilize one million believers to pray for the nations of the 10/40 Window during October 1993. Reports flooded in, and after careful calculation we were amazed that the Lord had raised up more than 20 million home-based intercessors from 28,107 churches in different parts of the world. In addition, 188 prayer journey teams took 257 journeys, visiting most of the Window nations to pray on the soil and ask God for spiritual breakthroughs.

In 1995, building on the prayer momentum of the previous two years, the *Praying Through The Window II* initiative focused on the 100 "Gateway Cities" of the 10/40 Window. The commitment from intercessors exceeded expectation, as more than 35 million praying saints of God participated. Moreover, the number of prayer journey teams more than doubled to 407; the teams took 607 prayer

journeys, with 3,000 Christians traveling to most of the "Gateway Cities" to intercede for penetration of the Gospel in those key places.

Praying Through The Window III in 1997 focused on the unreached people groups. This time, nearly 27 million intercessors from 121 nations prayed for the lost of the Window. The 27 million actual participants represent 42 percent of those who originally registered for the prayer campaign. Christian Information Network logged 471 prayer teams that took 563 journeys to the Window countries.

Praying Through The Window IV: Light the Window was our final prayer initiative of the millennium. It culminated in October 1999 when millions of believers across the globe came into agreement while praying through the 31-day prayer calendar. *Praying Through The Window IV: Light the Window* returned to its original focal point of praying specifically for the Window countries, while incorporating the strategic prayer information of the other efforts.

The Vision Expands Globally

Once the Church becomes informed and begins to pray for the perishing, it reawakens to its responsibility to fulfil the Great Commission. The *Praying Through The Window* emphasis of focusing intercession on the 10/40 Window and sending prayer journey teams is proving to be an effective means of motivating the Church to preach the Gospel everywhere, until every nation knows the glory of Christ's love.

Home-based intercessors who become prayer journeyers have started down an irreversible course that will change their lives forever. Soon many are convicted by

a revelation of the truth from Romans 10:14: "How, then, can they call on the one they have not believed in? And how can they believe in the one of whom they have not heard? And how can they hear without someone preaching to them?" Prayer journeyers then begin to cry out, "Lord, I'm willing to be an answer to my prayers. I'll get the training I need. I'll return as a short-term or long-term missionary to help bring in the harvest."

As the Church awakens to the need of the 10/40 Window, many congregations have found their commitment to prayer and missions expanding as never before. An unprecedented number of believers are going on extended fasts, organizing prayer watches, taking prayer journeys, committing to short-term and long-term mission trips, and calling on the Name of the Lord to set captives free.

As a result, many congregations have moved to a new level of involvement in advancing the kingdom of God. These congregations are planting new churches among the unreached and allocating resources into the Window countries. Some church mission committees now evaluate requests for financial assistance with an eye on whether or not the work targets the unreached in the 10/40 Window.

This growth in commitment comes not only from churches in the United States and the West but also from non-Western countries. Even 10/40 Window nations themselves have dramatically increased their number of short- and long-term out reach teams. For example, believers from the Philippines are consciously focusing on sending missionaries and supporting missions efforts in 10/40 Window countries. Already 1,000 Filipino missionaries minister cross-culturally, many in the 10/40 Window. One Filipino minister now pastors one of the largest churches in the Arabian Peninsula. Filipino believers are also having

a major impact in the country of Myanmar, as well as in many other spiritually dark lands.

This is not an isolated example. In 1995, Japan—itself a Window country—sent 26 teams to pray in twelve 10/40 Window countries that it once either occupied or went to war against. During the 1997 *Praying Through The Window III* effort, South Africa mobilized more than one million home- based intercessors and sent 30 teams to pray in the 10/40 Window. Furthermore, David Wang, International Director of Asian Outreach, has rallied as many as 25 million believers to pray during the *Praying Through The Window* initiatives. Many of these believers are from Mainland China!

The spreading wave of global involvement in frontier missions outreach has important implications. Because of visa restrictions, citizens of certain countries cannot travel to some of the Window countries. In such a situation, Christians from "neutral countries" can play a strategic role. For example, Arab believers taking prayer journeys into other Arab countries draw less attention than intercessors from the West. The partnership of intercessors and missionaries from the Two-thirds World greatly accelerates the prospect of completing the Great Commission in our day.

Responding to the Call

As I (Beverly) have watched the *Praying Through The Window* initiatives unfold, the passion in my own heart for the lost has mushroomed. After the first *Praying Through The Window* initiative in 1993, several prayer journey teams reported that when their team members asked people if they knew Jesus, time after time people would reply, "I have never heard of that name." Reading these reports caused my heart to grieve. Chills ran through my body to think they had never heard the Name of our Lord and Savior—

Jesus Christ, the Son of the living God! This seems impossible in our era, when the amount of knowledge available doubles every eight years—and yet millions of people living in our generation still have not been reached with the Gospel message.

Would it be presumptuous to think that God has reserved this era of history to write 'Acts Chapter 29"? If there is any time when we need the supernatural power of God working strongly with His Church, it is now. We have God's mandate, the technology, the wealth, and the heart to assure that billions in the 10/40 Window hear a clear presentation of the Gospel in a culturally sensitive manner and in their own language.

A growing number of national and international Christians believe that, if we join forces, the 10/40 Window will be reached in our generation. To do this, we cannot carry on business as usual, especially when it comes to allocation of our financial resources. According to GEM/ World Evangelization Research Center, Christian church and parachurch income worldwide totals an estimated US $207 billion, with only US $11.2 billion of that going towards missions. Of the missions dollars, an estimated 87 percent targets those who are already Christians, while another 12 percent goes towards evangelized non-Christians. In other words, only one percent of annual missions resources—roughly one-twentieth of one percent of total church and parachurch income—targets the unevangelized (people who have never heard the Gospel), the vast majority of whom live in the 10/40 Window!

Did God increase the prosperity of the Church so that we would spend the wealth on ourselves and our own desires? Are we in a state of lethargy as we succumb to the craving for our own comfort? The whole Body of Christ must awake to the vast need of the 10/40 Window and

remember our responsibility to take the Gospel to the ends of the earth. It is time to unify and bring together kingdom funding and resources to reach this region. The resources are available. The challenge to the Body of Christ worldwide is to invest appropriate finances in the world's area of deepest spiritual need.

The unreached in the 10/40 Window are calling to the Church of Jesus Christ, crying out, "Come over to the 10/40 Window and help us." Let us respond with a reverberating, "Yes, we are coming at once to preach the Gospel" (Acts 16:9-10).

We must remember, as Ephesians 6:12 says, that "our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly realms." We can use our delegated authority in Jesus' Name, apply the Blood of Jesus, persevere in prayer, and render ineffective the evil one's grip on nations. As we pray, God will raise up the leaders and policies of His choice, as he did in Daniel's time.

This is a crucial time for Christians to respond with acts of love and kindness. It is our Lord's command to us to restore lands and redeem nations (Isa. 58:10—12). "This is how we know what love is: Jesus Christ laid down his life for us. And we ought to lay down our lives for our brothers" (1 John 3:16).

Only the Gospel of Jesus Christ can free people from the devastation caused by worship of and enslavement to the forces of darkness (Jer. 10:11-16). No other region is under greater bondage to these forces than the 10/40 Window.

We Are Called and Commissioned

Now is the time for the Body of Christ to come to grips with these questions: Is our God worthy of worship, adoration, and praise? Do we sincerely believe that the Lord is more powerful than Satan and his army? Is God really concerned about the lost and their plight? If we answer "yes" we have a mandate from God to combat the forces of idolatry holding the 10/40 Window in bondage. We must take the Gospel message, with the Holy Spirit's power, to the Window nations as the Apostle Paul did—"not with wise and persuasive words, but with a demonstration of the Spirit's power, so that faith [the Window nations] might not rest on men's wisdom, but on God's power" (1 Cor. 2:4-5).

The Church of Jesus Christ has been commanded by God to go and take back the defiled land and to carry the Good News to the ends of the earth. We see this powerfully illustrated throughout the Book of Acts. The apostle Paul, called and commissioned by God, took three missionary journeys throughout 19 provinces of the ancient world. Interestingly, many of these areas lie within the 10/40 Window.

The ancient Church had its roots in this now spiritually dark area of the world. But the Church lost its authority in this region where Christianity once thrived. How did this happen? The Church grew weak, complacent, and self-absorbed. While the Church focused on itself and failed to reach out to those who did not know Jesus Christ, the enemy infiltrated the region. Now the challenge has been passed to a new generation. We must rise up and take the Gospel to these desolate lands. It is our responsibility to lead the captives out of captivity. We must exercise our God-given authority over the powers of darkness.

The Bible gives us models in which believers overthrew the powers of darkness and took back defiled land. God promised Moses and Joshua, "Every place where you set your foot will be yours" (Deut. 11:24; Josh. 1:3). The Old

Testament tells of foreigners who learned to worship and believe in the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob. In the New Testament era, the kingdom of God advanced even further. Jesus gave the gift of eternal life to the Samaritan woman, and Paul preached to the Gentiles. Empowered by the Holy Spirit, Jesus went into foreign territories, and the people flocked to Him. As the apostles preached the Gospel near and far, the Lord added believers to their number daily.

According to Acts 14:16, God at one time let all nations go their own way, but now He is drawing them to Himself. This is true in the 10/40 Window today. The Father is concerned about the people in the Window who do not yet have a personal relationship with His Son. It is their turn to hear this Good News, and our responsibility, according to Jesus' commission in Matthew 28:18-20, to bring it to them!

Will we go? Will we take up the challenge? Are we willing to minister to the needs of some of the world's neediest people? May God place in each of our hearts His passionate love for the lost and perishing in the 10/40 Window!



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